

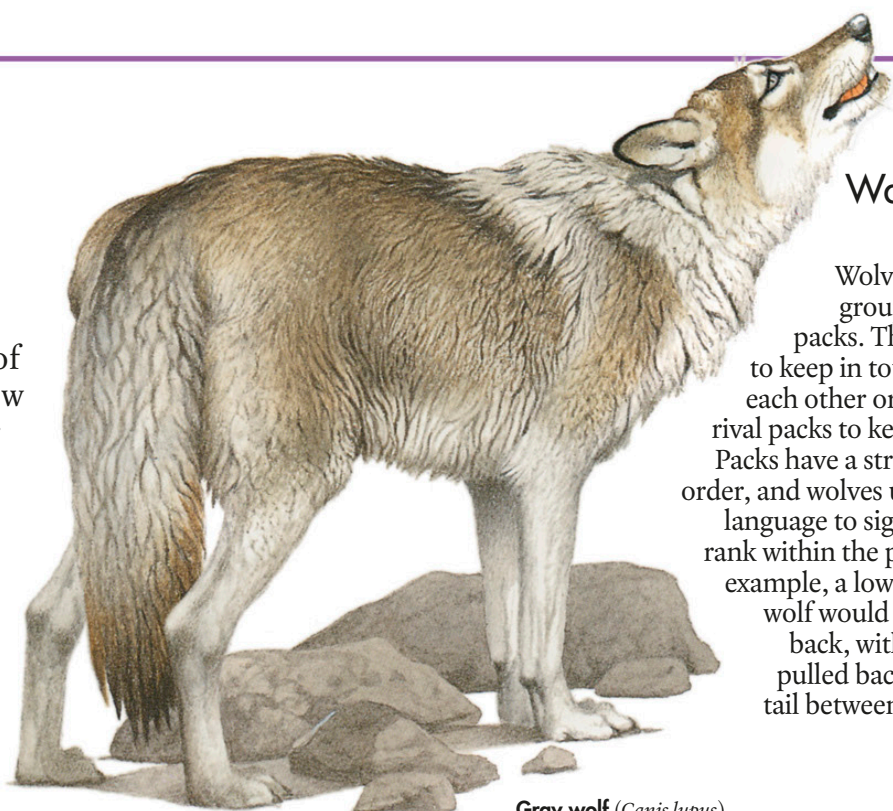
Siberia



THE CONIFER FORESTS OF SIBERIA in northern Asia make up the largest area of forest in the world. The cones of the larch, fir, and spruce trees that grow there provide a vital source of food for animals, especially during the winter.

South of the forests lies Lake Baikal. This lake has been isolated for millions of years, and many animals there are not found anywhere else in the world. North of the forest belt lies the barren Arctic wastes, or tundra.

During the tundra winter, which lasts for nine months each year, many animals move south to the shelter of the conifer forests. The brief tundra summer is a time of plenty, when it is light for 24 hours a day.



Warning howl

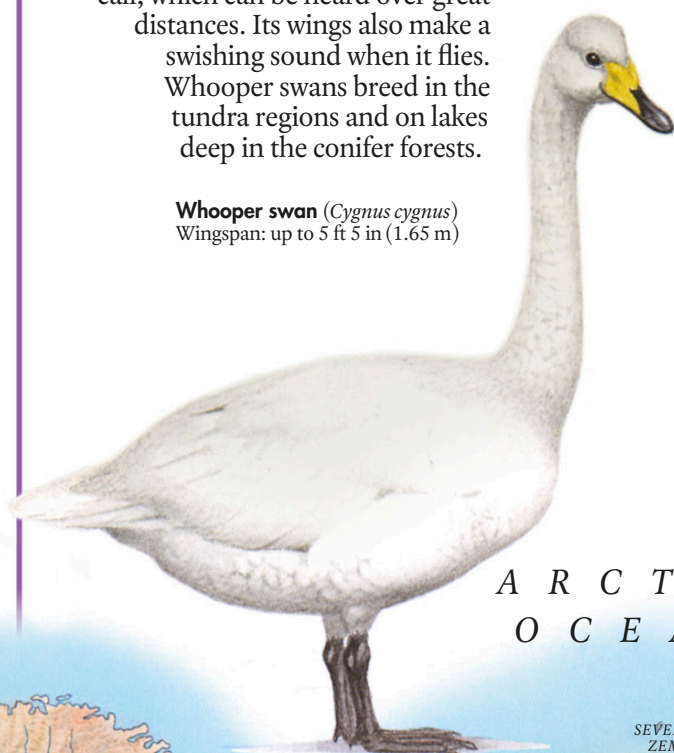
Wolves live in groups called packs. They howl to keep in touch with each other or to warn rival packs to keep away. Packs have a strict social order, and wolves use body language to signal their rank within the pack. For example, a low-ranking wolf would lie on its back, with its ears pulled back and its tail between its legs.

Gray wolf (*Canis lupus*)
Body length: up to 4 ft 3 in (1.3 m)
Tail: up to 20 in (52 cm)

Trumpet call

The whooper swan is one of the noisiest swans in the world. It gets its name from its loud, trumpeting call, which can be heard over great distances. Its wings also make a swishing sound when it flies. Whooper swans breed in the tundra regions and on lakes deep in the conifer forests.

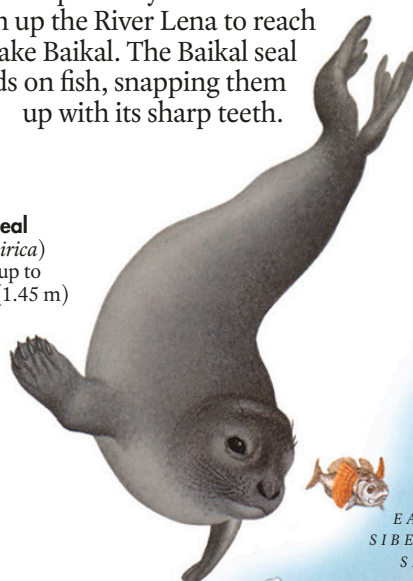
Whooper swan (*Cygnus cygnus*)
Wingspan: up to 5 ft 5 in (1.65 m)



Unique seal

The Baikal seal is the only seal that lives in fresh water. It is related to the ringed seals that live in the Arctic Ocean. Millions of years ago, its ancestors probably swam from this ocean up the River Lena to reach Lake Baikal. The Baikal seal feeds on fish, snapping them up with its sharp teeth.

Baikal seal (*Pusa sibirica*)
Length: up to 4 ft 9 in (1.45 m)

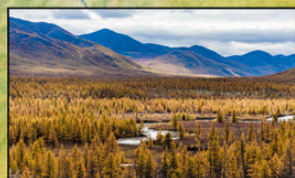


Wax droplets

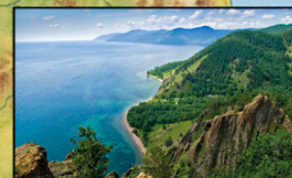
The waxwing is named after the red dots on its wings, which look like drops of wax. It feeds on fruit and insects, and relies mainly on berries in winter. The waxwing digests its food quickly—seeds can pass through its digestive system in as little as 16 minutes.



Bohemian waxwing (*Bombycilla garrulus*)
Length: up to 9 in (23 cm)



The huge expanses of Siberian forests cover an area one-third larger than the United States.



Lake Baikal is the deepest and oldest lake on Earth. It also contains more water than any other lake.